4
THE ANATOMY OF A VISUAL MESSAGE

We express and receive visual messages on three levels: representationally—what we see and recognize from environment and experience; abstractly—the kinesthetic quality of a visual event reduced to the basic elemental visual components, emphasizing the more direct, emotional, even primitive message-making means; symbolically—the vast world of coded symbol systems which man has created arbitrarily, and to which he has attached meaning. All these levels of information retrieval are interconnected and overlapping, but can be sufficiently distinguished from each other so that they can be analyzed both as to their value as potential tactics for message-making and their quality in the process of seeing.

Vision defines the act of seeing in all its ramifications. We see in sharp detail and learn and recognize all the elemental visual material in our lives in order to negotiate most competently in the world. This is our shared world of sky and sea, trees, grass, sand, earth, day, night; this is the world of nature. We see the world we make, a world of cities, airplanes, houses, machinery; this is the world of manufacture and the complexity of modern technology. We learn instinctively both to understand and maneuver psychophysiologically in the environment and intellectually to live with and operate those mechanical objects which are necessary to our survival. Both instinctively and intellectually, much of the learning process is visual. Sight is the only necessity for visual understanding. One does not need to be literate to speak or understand language; one need not be visually literate to make or understand visual messages. These abilities are intrinsic in man and will emerge, to some extent, with or without teaching or models. As they develop in history, so they develop in the child. The visual input is of profound importance to understanding and survival. Yet the whole area of vision has been compartmentalized and de-emphasized as a primary means for communication. One explanation of this rather negative approach is that visual talent and competency were not considered available to all people, as verbal literacy was thought to be. If this were ever true, it certainly is no longer. Part of the present and most of the future will be made by a generation conditioned by photography, film, and television, and to whom camera and visual computer will be an intellectual adjunct. One means of communication does not negate the other. If language can be compared with the visual mode, it must be understood that they are not in competition, but are merely to be weighed against each other in terms of effectiveness and viability. Visual literacy has been and can be only an extension of man's unique message-making capacity.

Replication of natural visual information should be within the ability of all. It should be taught. It can be learned. But it must be noted that there is no external arbitrary structural system as there is in language. The hard information that exists lies within the syntactical significance of the workings of the perceptions of the human organism. We see and what we see, we understand. Problem solving is inextricably connected with the visual mode. We can even reproduce the visual information around us through the camera, and, what is more, preserve it and extend it as simply as we have been able to through writing and reading and, more importantly, through printing and mass production of language. The difficult question is how. In what way can visual communication be understood and learned and expressed? Up to the invention of the camera, this was primarily the province of the artist, except for children and primitive people who did not know they could not do it. For example, we can all see and recognize a bird. We can extend this recognition to generalizing about an entire species and its attributes. To some observers, the visual information reaches no further than a primary level of information. To Leonardo da Vinci, a bird meant flying, and his investigation of that fact led him to try to invent flying machines. We see a bird, maybe a particular kind of bird, a dove, perhaps, and this has an extended meaning of love or peace. The visionary does not stop at the obvious; he sees beyond the surface visual facts into greater realms of meaning.

REPRESENTATION

Reality is the basic and dominating visual experience. The total general category of the bird is defined in elemental visual terms. A bird can be identified through a general shape, linear and detailed characteristics. All birds have some connecting, shared visual referents within the broader category. But in highly representational terms, birds fit into individual classifications, and knowledge of finer details of color, proportion, size, movement, and markings is necessary to differentiate between a seagull and a stork, a pigeon and a blue jay. One more level is a factor in the identification of individual birds. A particular canary may have individual visual traits that set it apart from the whole category of canaries. The general idea of a bird with shared characteristics moves toward the specific bird through increasingly detailed identifying factors. All this visual information is easily obtainable through various levels of the direct experience of seeing. We all

are the original camera; we all can store and recall for use this visual information with high visual effectiveness. The differences between the camera and the human brain lie in the questions of faithfulness of observation and ability to reproduce the visual information. It is clear that the artist and the camera hold some special expertise in both areas.

Beyond a realistic three-dimensional model, the closest thing to actually seeing a bird in direct experience would be a carefully exposed and focused photograph in full and natural color. The photograph matches the facility of the eye and brain, replicating the real bird in the real environment. We call the effect realistic. It should be noted, however, that in direct experience, or on any level of the scale of visual expression from photograph to impressionistic sketch, all visual experience is intensely subject to individual interpretation. From the "I see a bird" response to "I see flight," and to the multiple levels and degrees of meaning and intention between and beyond, the message is always open to subjective modification. We are all unique. Any inhibition about studying and even structuring the human visual potential born of a fear that such a development would lead to destruction of creative spirit, even conformity, is entirely without justification. Indeed, the mystique that has grown up around visualizers, from painters to architects, implies they must have a noncerebral approach to their work. The development of visual material should no more be dominated by inspiration and threatened by method than the converse. Making a film, designing a book, painting a painting, are all complicated ventures that must utilize both inspiration as well as method. Rules do not threaten creative thinking in mathematics; grammar and spelling do not impede creative writing. Coherence is not unaesthetic, and a well-expressed visual idea should have the same beauty and elegance as a mathematical theorem or a well-wrought sonnet.

The photograph is the most technically dependable means of representing visual reality. The invention of the "camera obscura" in the Renaissance as a toy for seeing the environment reproduced on wall or floor was only one step of a many branched tree that has made it possible through film and photography to arrive at the enormous and powerful effect the magic of the lens has had on our society. From the camera obscura to the mass media of film and printed photograph has been a slow but steady progression of more perfected technical means to fix and hold the picture and show it to millions the world over. Photography has been an accomplished fact for more than a hundred years. The many steps from the one, inclusive, nonreproducible "Daguerreotype" to the negative, multiple-print collotype, to flexible Kodak film, to 35 mm motion picture film, to the slowly improving methods of reproducing the continuous tone photograph through halftone plates for mass printing, to coated stock for finer printing—all have led to the pervasiveness of photography, both still and motion, in modern society. Through the photograph, an almost incomparably real, visual report of an occurrence in the daily printed newspaper or the weekly or monthly magazine, society sits shoulder to shoulder with history. The extension of this unique reportorial ability reaches into film, which even more accurately reproduces reality, and then to the electronic miracle of television, which allowed the world to share the first footstep of the first man on the moon, simultaneously with its occurrence. The concept of time was changed by mass printing; the concept of space was forever modified by the picture-making capacity of the camera.

A bird, then, can be fixed in time and space through a photograph (4.1). A highly realistic painting or drawing can come close to accomplishing the same thing. The artist is a necessary ingredient of this form. The drawings of Audubon, for example, were intended to be used as technical reference, and therefore are very realistic. Audubon studied and recorded the many varieties of birds of our country in astonishing and painstaking detail (4.2). We can say of his work: it is lifelike.

FIGURE 4.1

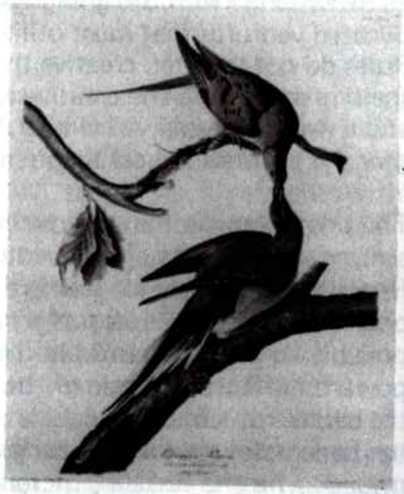


FIGURE 4.2

What we mean is the intention of the artist was to make the bird (or whatever is being visually reported on) look as much as possible as it looks naturally. Audubon was not only making a picture, he was also recording and supplying data for students that was dependable in identification, putting on paper visual information that could be used archivally for reference. In some ways, the photograph could be judged as more closely like life, but there is some argument that the artist's work is cleaner and clearer because he can control and manipulate it. This is the beginning of a process of abstraction, the removal of extraneous detail, the emphasis of distinguishing features.

The process of abstraction is one of distillation, the reduction of multiple visual factors to only the essential and most typical features of what is being represented. But if it is the movement of a bird that is to be emphasized, static and complete detail are ignored as in the sketch 4.3. In both cases of visual license, the final form follows the communication needs. In both cases, enough of the bird detail from life is present in the visual information to make the person who can recognize a bird able to recognize it in the sketches. Further deletion of detail toward total abstraction can take two paths: abstraction toward symbolism, sometimes with experienced meaning, sometimes with arbitrarily attached meaning, and pure abstraction, the reducing of the visual statement down to the basic elements, bearing no connection to any representational information drawn from experience of the environment.

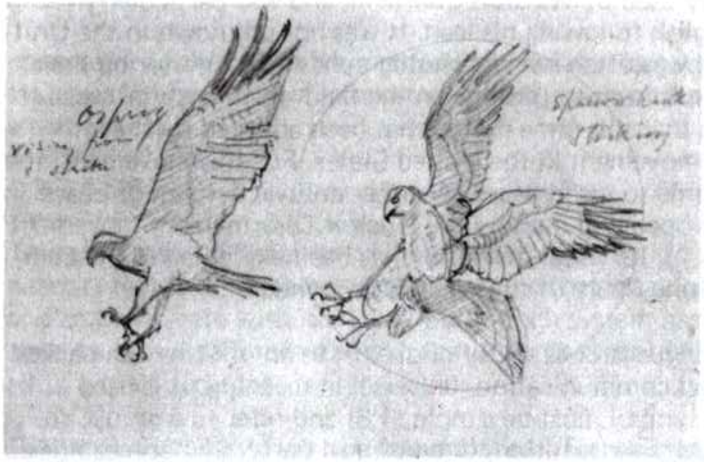


FIGURE 4.3

SYMBOLISM

Abstraction toward symbolism requires ultimate simplicity, the reduction of visual detail to the irreducible minimum. A symbol, in order to be effective, must not only be seen and recognized but also remembered and even reproduced. It cannot, by definition, have a great deal of detailed information. It can, however, still retain some of the real qualities of a bird, as shown in Figure 4.4. In Figure 4.5, the same basic visual information of the bird shape with the addition of only

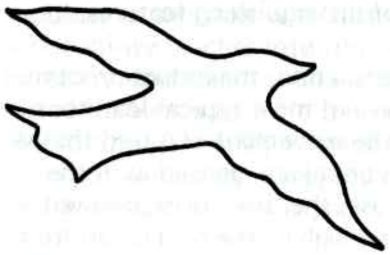


FIGURE 4.4

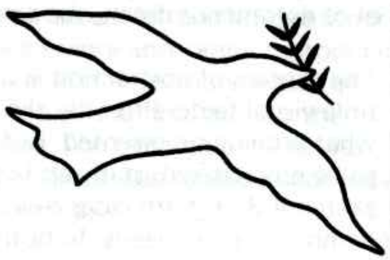


FIGURE 4.5

an olive branch, became the easily recognized symbol of peace. In this case, some education of the public may be necessary for the message to be clear. But the more abstract the symbol, the more penetration of the public mind is necessary for the education to its meaning. Figure 4.6 was once, in the symbolic gesture of World War II, the sign for the earnestly sought victory over the Germans in the war. It was frequently used by Winston Churchill, and was particularly taken up by the English following his lead. It was not unknown in the United States, and was often seen in photographs of GI's gesturing their hope of triumph from troopships, in the field, from hospital beds. It is truly ironic that this same gesture has been adopted by the anti-Vietnam war movement in the United States. For this movement, the gesture has come to mean peace. Another antiwar symbol of peace was first developed and used by the Nuclear Disarmament movement in England (4.7). Its visual derivation has been explained as the combination into one figure of the semaphore symbols for N and D.

Not only in language does the symbol exist as an information-packed means of visual communication, universal in meaning. It is used broadly. The symbol must be simple (4.8) and refer to a group, an idea, a business, an institution, or a political party. Sometimes it is abstracted from nature. It is even more effective for the transmission of information if it is a totally abstract figure (4.9). In this form it be-

FIGURE 4.6

FIGURE 4.7

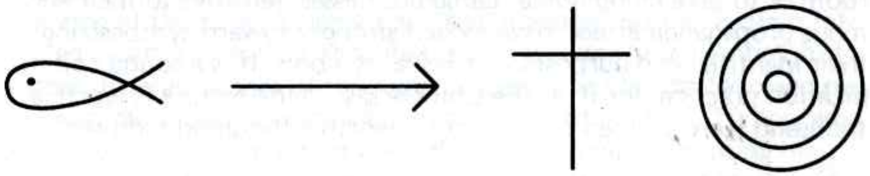


FIGURE 4.8

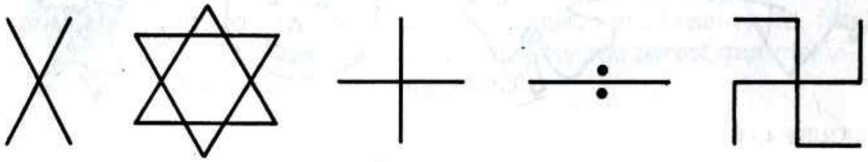


FIGURE 4.9

comes a code that serves as an adjunct to written language. The code system of numbers provides examples of figures which are also abstract concepts.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 0

There are many types of specialized coded information used by engineers, architects, builders, electricians. One that many people learn and communicate with is music (4.10). Each system has been developed to capsulize information so that it can be recorded and expressed to a mass audience.

Religion and folklore are rich in symbolism. The winged heel of Mercury, Atlas holding the world on his shoulders, the witch's broom, are just a few. Most familiar to us, as a visual language we all can nego-

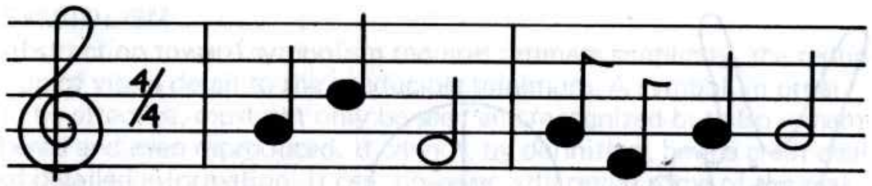


FIGURE 4.10

ciate, is the symbolism of the holidays (4.11). Before our visual education, such as it was, stopped so suddenly after grammar school, all of us drew and colored these familiar symbols to decorate the classroom or to take along home. Large businesses, sensitive to their enormous propaganda effect, have moved strongly toward synthesizing their identities and purposes with visual symbols. It is a sound communication practice, for if, as the Chinese say, "One picture is worth a thousand words," then one symbol is worth a thousand pictures.

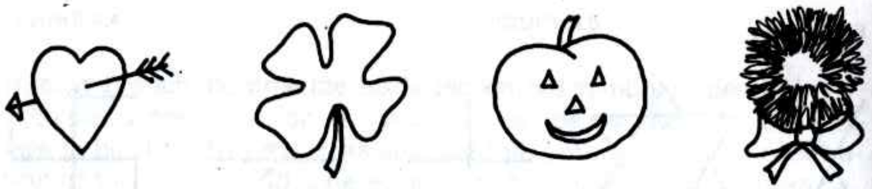


FIGURE 4.11

ABSTRACTION

Abstraction, however, need have no relationship to actual symbol-making when symbols have meaning only because it is pinned on them. The reduction of all we see to the basic visual elements is also a process of abstraction which, in fact, has far more significance to the understanding and structuring of visual messages. The more representational the visual information, the more specific its reference; the more abstract, the more general and all-encompassing it is. Abstraction, visually, is simplification toward a more intense and distilled meaning. As already demonstrated, human perception strips away surface detail in response to the need to establish balance and other visual rationalizations. But the importance to meaning does not end there. Abstraction can exist in visual matters not only in the purity of a visual statement stripped down to minimal representational information, but also as pure abstraction, which draws no connection with familiar visual data, environmental or experiential. The school of abstract painting is associated with the twentieth century, and includes the

work of Picasso, who has himself stretched his personal style from expressionistic to classical, to semi-abstract, to abstract (4.12). On the one hand, he modified the visual facts to emphasize color and light, but he retained the realistic, recognizable information. In another approach, an almost purist devotion to representational visual information, he echoed the godlike quality of man in only the slightly exaggerated realism of a classic style. His great liberties with reality resulted first in highly maneuvered effects, and finally in the complete abandonment of the familiar for space and tone, color and texture. This final visual style then was concerned only with the compositional questions and content answers of design. In this evolution from concern with observing and recording the world around to experimenting at the core of elemental visual message-making, Picasso followed a path of development that is not necessarily sequential, but rather different stages of the same process. The path he followed may be even more clearly observable in the work of J. M. W. Turner, who as a young man pursued his craft almost like a reporter, using his painting to detail and preserve his own time. But Turner became interested in the methods he used to develop a painting, particularly in the sketch. Slowly his work evolved from a masterful representational technique to a loose and probing suggestion of reality, to, finally, almost totally abstract paintings with only the barest minimal visual clues of what he was picturing (4.13).

FIGURE 4.12 (continued on next page)

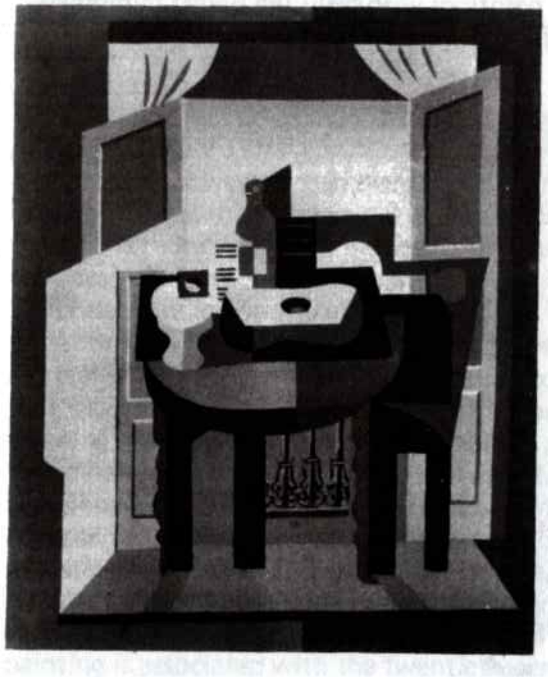


FIGURE 4.12 (continued)

FIGURE 4.13

The multiple levels of visual expression that include representationality, abstraction, and symbolism offer choices of both manner and means to the solution to visual problems. Abstraction has been associated particularly with painting and sculpture as the unique pictorial expression of the twentieth century. But many visual formats are by their own nature abstract. A house, a dwelling, the simplest or most complex shelter, does not look like anything drawn from nature. In other words, a house is not patterned after a tree, which in some circumstances could be described as shelter; it looks like what it does; its form follows its function. It is at its elemental level an abstract, dimensional volume. But the possible solutions for man's need for shelter and protection are infinite. They can be inspired by utility (4.14), pride (4.15), expression (4.16), and communication and protection (4.17). So the use that a building will be put to is one of the strongest determining factors in its size, shape, proportion, tone, color, and texture. Form, in this case, as in other visual contexts, follows function. But the where and when questions are also profoundly important to the structural and style decisions that figure in the design and building of housing. The where is significant as to climate, since the requirements for shelter differ dramatically from the equator (4.18) to the far North (4.19). Where something is being built also influences the availability of materials. The branches and leaves of the tropics are simply not available in the frozen reaches of the Arctic. Before it is possible for form to follow the function, the form must be synthesized of a material or materials readily available in the environment. Not just geographical location, but historical restraints, that is, when

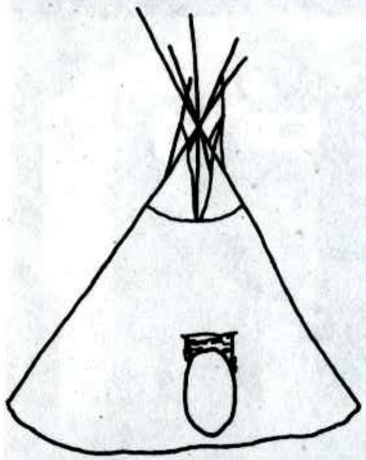


FIGURE 4.14

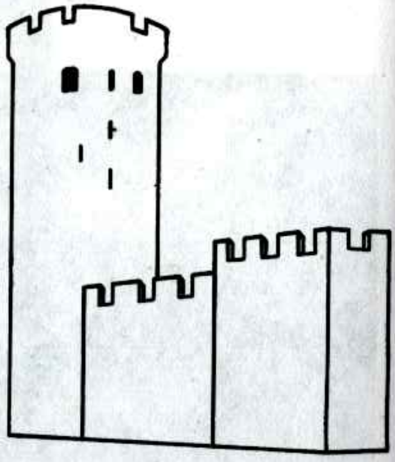


FIGURE 4.15

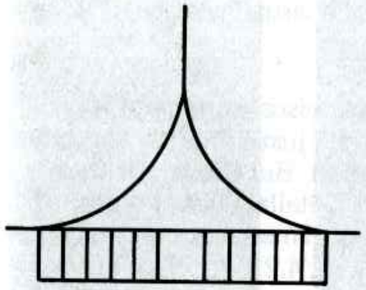


FIGURE 4.16

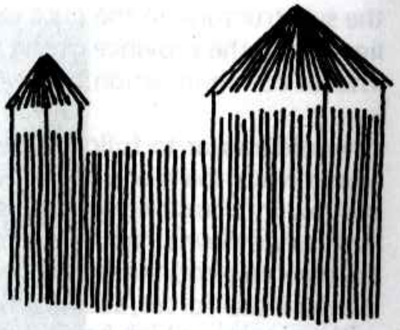


FIGURE 4.17

FIGURE 4.18

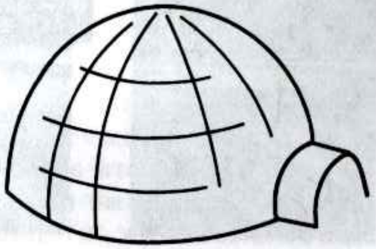


FIGURE 4.19

something is designed and built, often controls decisions of style and culture. For many of the above reasons, a particular design solution is arrived at and repeated with very little modification until it becomes identifiable in association with a certain period in time and a particular geographic location (4.18, 4.19). The last determining factor in this process is the idea and preference of the individual. Do not most people who have a hand in the designing and building of a house feel that it represents them? Even the fact of choice in the purchase of a house is considered a manifestation of their taste, and therefore, of them. How much visual information there is in all of this, and yet, consider, what we have been examining is the design and construction of buildings, all of which are abstract and possibly to some small extent, symbolic, but in no way representational. The meaning lies in the substructure, in the pure elemental visual forces, and because it lies within the province of the anatomy of a visual message, it is very intense communication.

It would appear to follow that any abstract visual statement is profound while the representational is, after all, just imitation and quite shallow in terms of depth of communication. But the fact is this: even as we view a highly representational, detailed, visual report of the environment, there coexists another visual message, exposing the elemental visual forces, abstract in quality (4.20, 4.21, 4.22), but packed with meaning, which has enormous power over response. The abstract understructure is the composition, the design. The potential for mes-

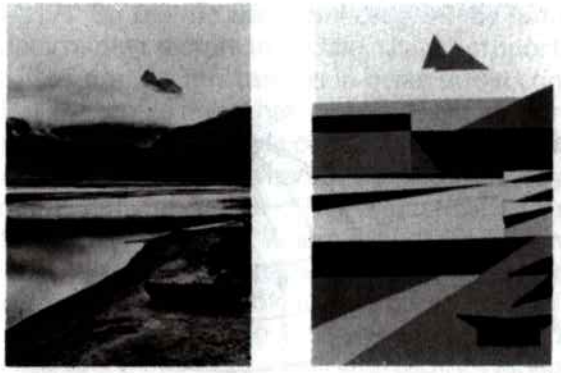


FIGURE 4.20

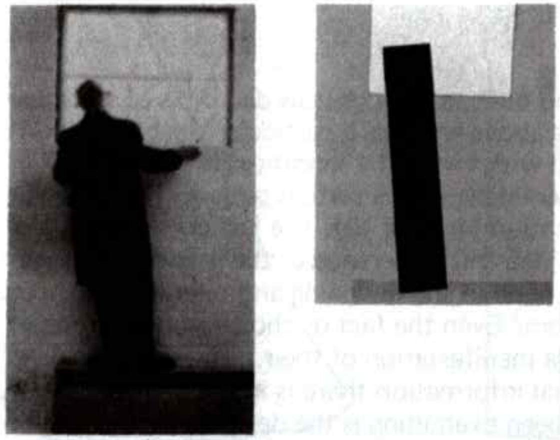


FIGURE 4.21

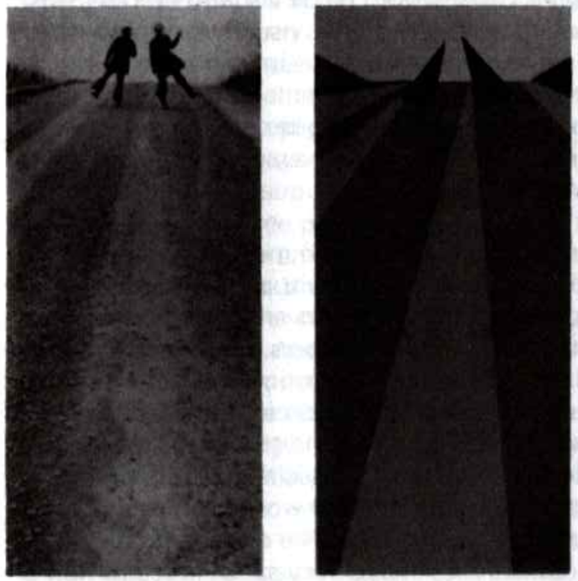


FIGURE 4.22

sage-making in the reduction of the realistic visual information to abstract components lies in the response of the arrangement to the effect intended. Can there be hard meaning in the abstract understructure? Music is, after all, totally abstract.... Yet, we characterize musical content as happy, sad, lively, turgid, martial, romantic. How do we arrive at such information identification, which is rather universally held? Some meanings attached to musical composition are associations to reality, some are drawn from man's own psychophysical structure, his kinesthetic relationship to the music. So we say of music: it is totally abstract, but there are aspects of it which may be interpreted with reference to shared meaning. In fact, the abstract quality may indeed increase the obtainability of the message and mood. In the visual formats, it is the composition which is the abstract counterpart of music, whether it is the visual statement itself or the understructure. The abstract conveys the essential meaning, cutting through the conscious to the unconscious, from the experience of the substance in the sensory field directly to the nervous system, from the event to perception.

INTERACTION AMONG THE THREE LEVELS

The levels of all visual stimuli contribute to the process of conceiving and making and refining all visual work. To be visually literate, it is extremely necessary that the creator of the visual work be aware of each of these individual levels; but also it is important that the viewer or subject have equal awareness of them. Each level, representational, abstract, symbolic, has its own unique characteristics which can be isolated and defined, but they in no way conflict. In fact they overlap, interact, and enhance the individual qualities of each other.

The representational visual information is the most effective level to utilize in the strong, direct reporting of the visual details of the environment, both natural and made. Until the invention of the camera, only those highly talented and trained members of a community could produce the kinds of drawings and painting and sculpture that could successfully represent visual information as it appears to the eye. This facility has always been admired and the artist who could produce it has always been viewed as very special. There is a kind of magic in the very detailed and realistic visual work even though it might be regarded as surface or superficial. The comment about a portrait that "it looks just like me," has a very special recognition of the artist. But all this has changed with the camera. There is no question that, from a snapshot to the meticulously lit studio portrait, the problem of likeness doesn't even enter into the evaluation of a portrait. The camera delivers a visual report of whatever is in front of it with startling dependability and detail. It reports what it sees almost to a fault. But the visual communicator has many ways to control the results both in terms of style and technique. Nevertheless, representationality, the realistic report of what it sees, is natural to the camera and may well be one of the major factors in an increasing interest in the second level of visual information, the abstract.

Abstraction has, as already noted, been the primary tool in the development of a visual plan. It is most useful in the process of uncommitted exploration of a problem and development of visible options and solutions. The nature of abstraction releases the visualizer from the demands of representing the finished final solution, and so allows the underlying structural forces of the compositional questions to surface, the pure visual elements to appear, and the techniques to be applied with direct experimentation. It is a dynamic process filled with starts and false starts but free and easy by nature. It is not surprising that many artists are interested in the purity of the level. As noted above, the artist and visualizer may well have been released into a freer approach to visual expression by the natural mechanical prowess of the

camera to reproduce a final, finished visual statement. Why compete? There always have been artists who have the training, the talent, and the interest to continue in the tradition of realism, from Salvador Dali and his hyper-realistic but subjectively interpreted surrealistic works to the subtly representational paintings of Andrew Wyeth. There, no doubt, always will be.

The interest in the free probes for visual solutions, however, is an unavoidable must for any artist or designer who must start from the blank sheet and work toward composing and completing a visual plan. This is not true for the photographer or filmmaker or television cameraman. In each case, the basic visual work is dominated by realistic information in detail, and therefore, inhibits the filmic thinker from investigation of the visual pre-plan. In film and television there is a component of language inherent in the planning process, but sad to say, words are frequently used in the previsualization of a film rather than visuals. A deeper awareness of the character of the abstract level of visual messages on the part of all those who use the lens can open up new avenues for visual expression of ideas.

The last level of visual information, the symbolic, has been commented on at great length. The symbol is anything from a simplified picture to a highly complex system of attached meaning like language or numbers. In all its formulations it can reinforce message and meaning in visual communication many ways. In print, it is a large and important component of the total character of a book, a magazine, or a poster, and must be dealt with in the forming of a design as abstract visual data, despite the fact that it is information with its own integrity and form. For the designer it is an interactive force which must be dealt with in terms of meaning and visual appearance.

The process of creating a visual message can be described as a series of steps from a number of rough sketches probing for solutions to increasingly refined versions toward a final choice and decision. It is necessary to add a proviso, namely: the word final describes any point the visualizer determines. The key to perception lies in the fact that the whole creative process seems to reverse for the receiver of visual messages. First, he sees the visual facts, either information drawn from the environment which can be recognized, or symbols which can be defined. On the second level of perception, the subject sees the compositional content, the basic elements, the techniques. It is an unconscious process, but through it is the cumulative experience of information input. If the original compositional intentions of the visual message-maker are successful, that is, have been brought to a sound solution, the result is coherent and clear, a working whole. If the solutions are extremely successful, the relationship between content and form can be described as elegant. With bad strategic decisions, the final visual effect is ambiguous. Aesthetic judgments involving words like "beauty" need not be involved at this level of interpretation, but rather left to a more subjective point of view. The interaction between purpose and composition, between syntactical structure and visual substance, must be mutually strengthening to be visually effective. Together, they represent the most important force in all visual communication, the anatomy of a visual message.

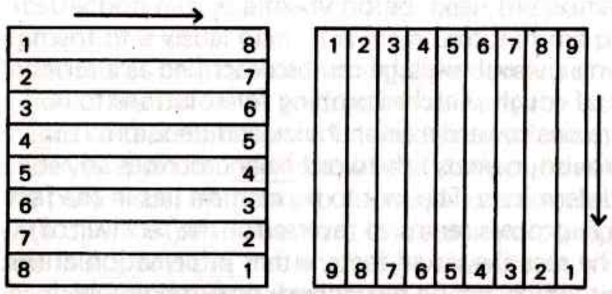
EXERCISES

1. Photograph or find an example of each of the three levels of visual material, Representational, Abstract, Symbolic.

2. Take a photograph out-of and in focus and study the abstract, out-of-focus version for its compositional feeling. Evaluate how you feel the abstract message relates to the representational statement. Could it be improved by changing the point of view of the camera? Make a rough sketch to see how you might change it by moving the camera.

3. Find a symbol which you can draw, and compare the ease with which you can reproduce it with the letters of the alphabet or numerals.

4. Divide up a photograph into even strips either horizontally or vertically and rearrange the order with some plan.



Any rearrangement will break down the representational order and reveal the abstract compositional structure.